A FREE, PLAIN-SPOKEN GUIDE



# Apps That Actually Help

## Genuinely Useful Everyday Apps for Cooking, Health, Money, Safety, Accessibility, and Family Care

Free and low-cost picks • Real prices
Privacy cautions • No affiliate links

D.A. Williams

# Apps That Actually Help

## A Plain-Spoken Guide to Genuinely Useful Everyday Apps for Cooking, Health, Money, Safety, Accessibility, and Family Care

**D.A. Williams**

Published by Red Pills of Freedom

Free to share. Please pass it on to someone who needs it.

*Dedicated to Mom, Janis Fredlund*

**Free to share. Please pass it on to someone who needs it.**

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This book is for general education. It is not legal, medical, or financial advice. No company paid to be included, and there are no affiliate links. Prices, features, and privacy details come from each app's official store listing or website as of October 2026, and they change often. **Always check the official listing before you download or pay.**

The short scenes marked "Example" in this book are made up to show how something works. They are not stories about real people.

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INTRODUCTION

# A Few Good Apps Beat a Hundred Okay Ones

There are millions of apps. Most of us need about a dozen good ones.

This book is a short list of apps and built-in phone features that can genuinely make everyday life easier: cooking a meal, keeping track of medicines, checking a benefits balance, blocking scam calls, reading a label when your eyesight is poor, or letting family know you got home safe.

## How the apps in this book were chosen

- **Useful for everyday people,** including older adults, families, caregivers, and people with disabilities.
- **Free or low-cost first.** Government and nonprofit tools are preferred. When an app has paid features, this book says so plainly and lists the prices shown on the official store page.
- **Described in their own words.** What each app "does" comes from its own website or official store

listing. This book does not test apps or rate them, and it does not repeat star ratings.

- **Privacy cautions for every app.** Each entry tells you what the app's official privacy label or policy says, and what to think about before you share personal information.
- **No affiliate links and no paid placements.** Nobody paid to be in this book.

## How to read each entry

Each app has a short profile:

- **Made by:** the company or agency that publishes it.
- **Where to get it:** the official website or store listing. (The full web address is in the Notes.)
- **Cost:** free, or free with paid options, with prices from the official listing.
- **What it does:** a summary of how the app describes itself.
- **Privacy notes:** what the app's privacy label or policy says, plus cautions.

**IMPORTANT: Prices and features change.** Everything in this book was checked in October 2026. Before you pay for anything, look at the current price on the official store page, and read what you're agreeing to.

CHAPTER 1

# Before You Download: Six Quick Checks

A helpful app can save you time and money. A fake or careless one can cost you both. These six checks take about two minutes.

## Check 1: Get apps only from the official store

On an iPhone, that's Apple's App Store. On most Android phones, it's Google Play. Avoid links in texts, emails, or pop-up ads that tell you to install something.

## Check 2: Look at who made it

Before you tap "Get" or "Install," look at the developer's name under the app's title. A government app should come from the agency itself. For example, the official IRS app on the App Store lists its developer as "Internal Revenue Service," and the official Medicare coverage app lists "Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services."[15,6]

Lookalike names are common. For example, when the App Store was searched in October 2026 for "Live

Transcribe," the top results were apps from other developers, not Google. Google's Live Transcribe is an Android app (see Chapter 6).[18,33] That doesn't mean those other apps are bad. It means you should check the developer every time.

## Check 3: Read the price line, including "In-App Purchases"

"Free" on a store listing can mean "free to download." If the listing also says **In-App Purchases**, the app sells upgrades or subscriptions inside it. Apple's App Store lists those prices on the app's page. This book lists them for each app.

## Check 4: Read the privacy label, and know what it is

Both stores show a privacy summary for each app. These summaries are written by the app maker. Apple's pages say this information "has not been verified by Apple."[10] Google Play says the developer "provided this information and may update it over time."[2] Treat the label as a starting point, not a guarantee.

## Check 5: Say no to permissions it doesn't need

The Federal Trade Commission (FTC) suggests going to your phone's privacy settings to see what information apps can access, like your location, contacts, or photos,

and turning off permissions that aren't needed or deleting apps that ask for a lot of permissions they don't need.[19] A recipe app doesn't need your contacts. A flashlight app doesn't need your location.

The FTC also notes that your phone has a setting to opt out of personalized ads from the company that makes the phone's operating system, usually in the "advertising" section of your privacy settings.[19]

## Check 6: Never type passwords or codes into an app because someone called and told you to

Treat any surprise caller who asks you to install an app as a likely scammer. Hang up and call the organization back at a number you already trust.

## What to do

1. Before any download, check the developer's name and the "In-App Purchases" line.
2. After you install, open your phone's settings and review that app's permissions.
3. If you're not sure, ask someone you trust to look with you.

CHAPTER 2

# Cooking, Groceries, and Food Safety

Good food is one of the simplest ways to care for yourself and the people you love. These apps help with recipes, storing food safely, and stretching a grocery budget.

## Mulberry Tree (Mulberry Tree Cooking)

- **Made by:** Mulberry Tree Cooking, LLC.[1,2]
- **Where to get it:** Apple App Store (listed as "Mulberry Tree Cooking") and Google Play (listed as "Mulberry Tree"). Website: mulberrytree.io.[1,2,3]
- **Cost:** Free to download, with in-app purchases. The App Store lists a "Monthly Plan" at $9.99 and a "Family Plan" at $99.99. The listing does not say how often the Family Plan is billed, so check before you buy.[1] Google Play also shows that the Android app offers in-app purchases.[2]
- **Platforms:** The App Store page labels it "Only for iPhone" and "Designed for iPhone," though its compatibility section also lists Macs with Apple M1

chips or later and Apple Vision. There is also an Android version on Google Play.[1,2]

- **What it does:** Both store listings describe it as "a farm-to-fork recipe community app that connects people through food, local farmers, and shared creativity." You can explore and share recipes, connect with farmers and local producers, and buy directly from them.[1,2] Its website says you can "buy your ingredients directly from farmers or the grocery store," get location-based suggestions for local producers, post recipes and "earn rewards," and take part in contests and community events.[3] The App Store's version history mentions buying recipe ingredients through Instacart and an improved farmers market checkout.[1]
- **Good to know:** Apple lists it in the **Social Networking** category with an **18+** age rating, citing things like user-generated content, messaging and chat, advertising, and contests. Google Play rates the Android app **Teen**.[1,2]
- **Privacy notes:** The two store labels don't match. Apple's label says the developer "does not collect any data from this app."[1] Google Play's label for the Android version says the app "may collect" location, personal info, and two other data types, that data is encrypted in transit, and that you can ask for your data to be deleted.[2] Because the app includes chat, community posts, and shopping, assume that what

you post and buy may be seen by others or shared with the sellers you buy from. Read the app's terms and privacy policy, and only share your location if you want local suggestions.

**Example (made up):** Rosa wants fresh eggs and honey from nearby farms. She uses a farm-to-fork app to find a local producer, reads the seller's details carefully, and pays through the app's own checkout instead of sending money by a payment app to a stranger who messaged her.

## USDA FoodKeeper

- **Made by:** U.S. Department of Agriculture (USDA) Food Safety and Inspection Service, developed with Cornell University and the Food Marketing Institute.[4]
- **Where to get it:** FoodSafety.gov, Apple App Store, and Google Play.[4,5]
- **Cost:** Free.[5]
- **What it does:** FoodSafety.gov says FoodKeeper "helps you understand food and beverages storage" and helps you "maximize the freshness and quality of items."[4] The app's listing says its storage times are "useful guidelines" and "not hard-and-fast rules."[5]
- **Privacy notes:** Apple's label says "Data Not Collected."[5]

## What to do

1. If you try Mulberry Tree, decide up front whether you want a paid plan, and check the billing details in the store before you tap “Subscribe.”
2. Keep FoodKeeper handy for “Is this still good?” questions, and remember its times are guidelines.

CHAPTER 3

# Health and Medicine

Health apps can be wonderful, and they can also collect some of the most private information you have. Use the free official tools first, and read privacy notes carefully on everything else.

> **REMEMBER: An app is not a doctor.** Use health apps for reminders and information. Ask your doctor or pharmacist about your own care.

## Medicare's "What's covered" app

- **Made by:** Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services (CMS).[6]
- **Where to get it:** Apple App Store and Google Play.[6,7]
- **Cost:** Free.[6]
- **What it does:** The listing calls it the "only official U.S. government Medicare app." It helps you understand the coverage offered by **Original Medicare** Part A and Part B, see information about your costs, learn about covered items and services, and browse free preventive services.[6]

- **Good to know:** It's about Original Medicare. If you have a Medicare Advantage plan, check with your plan too.
- **Privacy notes:** Apple's label lists only "Data Not Linked to You."[6]

## Medical ID (built into iPhone)

- **Made by:** Apple. It's part of the Health app that comes with iPhone.[8]
- **Cost:** Free, already on your iPhone.
- **What it does:** Apple says Medical ID "helps first responders access your critical medical information from the Lock screen, without needing your passcode," such as allergies, medical conditions, and who to contact in an emergency.[8]
- **How to set it up:** Open the Health app, tap the Summary tab, tap your profile picture, then tap **Medical ID**. Turn on **Show When Locked**, and if you want, turn on **Share During Emergency Call**. Tap Edit to add medications, allergies, conditions, and emergency contacts.[8]
- **Privacy notes:** Anyone holding your phone can see what you put in Medical ID if Show When Locked is on. Include only what you'd want a stranger helping you to know. Apple says it cannot read your Medical ID information when it is shared with emergency responders.[8]

- **Android phones** have their own emergency information settings. Where you find them depends on the phone maker, so check your phone maker's help pages.

## Medisafe Medication Management

- **Made by:** MediSafe Inc.[9]
- **Where to get it:** Apple App Store (and Apple Watch).[9]
- **Cost:** Free to download, with in-app purchases. The App Store lists premium options ranging from $2.99 to $39.99, including monthly upgrades and one-year subscriptions.[9] *Labeled: paid features.*
- **What it does:** It describes itself as a "Pill and Medicine Reminder." The listing says U.S. users can see drug-to-drug interaction warnings and import medicines using Health Records on iPhone.[9]
- **Privacy notes:** Apple's label lists "Data Not Linked to You." The App Store rates it 18+.[9] Your medicine list is sensitive. Read the privacy policy before you connect health records.
- **A free alternative:** Many phones have built-in reminders and alarms that work fine for a simple schedule.

## GoodRx

- **Made by:** GoodRx, Inc.[10]
- **Where to get it:** Apple App Store and goodrx.com.[10]

- **Cost:** The app and its prescription coupons are free to use. The listing also advertises telehealth and other services; check the price of any service before you use it.[10]
- **What it does:** The listing says you can find discounts on prescriptions, use "free digital coupons," track your medicines, and access telehealth. It also says plainly: "GoodRx is NOT insurance."[10]
- **Privacy notes:** This one deserves care. In 2023, the FTC took action against GoodRx, saying it had shared users' sensitive health information, including prescription medications and health conditions, with advertising companies like Facebook and Google, contrary to its privacy promises. Under the proposed order, GoodRx agreed to pay a $1.5 million civil penalty and was to be permanently banned from sharing user health information with certain third parties for advertising.[11] Today, Apple's privacy label for the app says data "linked to you" may be used for third-party advertising, including purchases, location, browsing history, identifiers, and usage data, and that health information may be used for the developer's own advertising or marketing.[10]
- **Tip:** Compare the coupon price with your insurance or Medicare price at the pharmacy counter. Ask your pharmacist which is lower.

## VA: Health and Benefits (for veterans)

- **Made by:** U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs.[12]
- **Where to get it:** Apple App Store.[12]
- **Cost:** Free.[12]
- **What it does:** The official VA app lets you refill and track VA prescriptions, send secure messages to your VA health care team, review appointments, check your disability rating, check claim or appeal status, submit evidence, and download common VA letters.[12]
- **Privacy notes:** Apple's label lists data linked to you and data not linked to you; no tracking is listed.[12] Sign in only through the official app, and never give your VA login to anyone who calls you.

## What to do

1. Set up Medical ID (or your Android phone's emergency information) today.
2. If you're on Original Medicare, install "What's covered."
3. For discount or reminder apps, read the privacy label first and share only what you need to.

CHAPTER 4

# Money and Benefits

Money apps can help you check balances, catch fraud early, and file paperwork without waiting on hold. They can also be targets for scammers, so stick to official apps.

## Propel (for EBT, SNAP, and WIC)

- **Made by:** Propel Inc., a private company.[13]
- **Where to get it:** Apple App Store and propel.app.[13,14]
- **Cost:** Free. Propel says it makes money through advertising.[14]
- **What it does:** Propel says it is "the simplest way to check your EBT balance." It shows your balance and transaction history, predicts deposit dates, sends benefit updates, and offers security features like EBT card locking and out-of-state transaction blocking. It also shows offers and job listings.[14,13] Propel says balance checking works in 49 states, D.C., and several territories, but not in Iowa.[14]
- **Privacy notes:** Propel says it connects to your state's benefits portal with your permission to gather your balance and history.[14] Apple's label lists data linked to you and data not linked to you.[13] Because it is ad-

supported, expect offers. You can always check your balance through your state's own EBT system instead.

## The official IRS app

- **Made by:** Internal Revenue Service.[15]
- **Where to get it:** Apple App Store (listed as "IRS").[15]
- **Cost:** Free.[15]
- **What it does:** Sign in with the same secure sign-in you use on IRS.gov to view your balance, make payments, check refund status, see tax records, and view notices. Without signing in, you can check refund status, make a guest payment, find free tax preparation help, and sign up for tax tips.[15]
- **Privacy notes:** Apple's label lists data linked to you and data not linked to you.[15] Scammers pretend to be the IRS. Use only the app from the developer "Internal Revenue Service," and never install anything because a caller "from the IRS" told you to.

## Credit freezes and the credit bureau apps

A **credit freeze** is one of the strongest, simplest protections against identity theft. The FTC says that while a freeze is in place, nobody can open a new credit account in your name; it is free to place and free to lift; and you need to contact all three credit bureaus: Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion.[16]

Each bureau offers its own app. For example:

- **myEquifax** (Equifax Inc.): free account with your Equifax credit report and score updates; paid plans add credit monitoring and identity protection.[17] *Labeled: paid upgrades available.* Apple's label lists data linked to you and data not linked to you.[17]
- **Experian** and **TransUnion** also have free apps in the App Store.[18]

**Privacy and money cautions:** Credit bureau apps often promote paid plans. You don't need to pay to freeze or unfreeze your credit.[16] If you only want a freeze, you can also do it on each bureau's website.

## What to do

1. Freeze your credit at all three bureaus. It's free.
2. Use only official apps for taxes and benefits.
3. If an app you use for money is ad-supported, don't tap offers you don't understand.

CHAPTER 5

# Safety and Scams

Your phone already has some of the best scam-blocking tools available, and your phone company probably offers more for free.

## Built-in: iPhone “Screen Unknown Callers”

- **Made by:** Apple. Built into iPhone.[20]
- **Cost:** Free. Apple notes that standard calling and data rates may apply with call screening.[20]
- **What it does:** In Settings, tap Apps, then Phone, then **Screen Unknown Callers**. You can choose **Ask Reason for Calling** (the caller is asked why they’re calling before your phone rings) or **Silence** (calls from numbers not in your contacts are silenced and sent to voicemail). You can also turn on Call Filtering for unknown callers and a spam filter.[20]
- **Important tip from Apple:** Add important numbers, like family, your doctor’s office, and your child’s school, to your Contacts so those calls always come through. If you call emergency services, call screening turns off for 24 hours.[20]

## Built-in: Android "Caller ID & spam protection"

- **Made by:** Google, in the Phone by Google app.[21]
- **Cost:** Free.
- **What it does:** It's on by default. It shows information about callers outside your contacts and warns about potential spam. You can also turn on "Filter spam calls." Some phones have "fake call detection," which can alert you if a caller impersonates one of your contacts.[21]
- **Privacy notes:** Google says that to use this feature, numbers that call you from outside your contacts are sent to Google to help identify them, and that Google doesn't get phone numbers from your contact list.[21]

## Free tools from your phone company

Verizon, AT&T, and T-Mobile each offer free spam and scam call protection for their customers, with paid upgrades. *Labeled: paid upgrades available.*

- **Verizon Call Filter** (Verizon Wireless): The free version identifies suspected spam, automatically blocks high-risk callers, and lets you report numbers. **Call Filter Plus** costs $3.99 per month, per line, after a 15-day trial for eligible customers, or $10.99 a month for accounts with three or more lines. If you do nothing after the trial, you're moved to the free version.[22]

- **AT&T ActiveArmor** (AT&T Services): The free service for AT&T wireless customers includes automatic fraud and spam call blocking, a personal block list, device security alerts, and data breach alerts. The App Store lists an "Advanced" upgrade at $7.00. AT&T notes it "may not detect all threats and may inadvertently block wanted calls."[23]
- **T-Mobile ScamShield** (T-Mobile): T-Mobile says ScamShield's free features include Scam Likely labels, Scam Block, spam calls sent to voicemail, Callback Protection, and Safe Web Browsing. You can turn on Scam Block in the T-Life app or by dialing **#662#** from your T-Mobile phone. ScamShield Premium adds extra features.[24]

**Privacy notes:** Apple's labels for the Verizon and AT&T apps list data linked to you.[22,23] Any call-blocking tool has to look at who is calling you to work.

## Bitwarden Password Manager

- **Made by:** Bitwarden Inc.[25]
- **Where to get it:** Apple App Store and bitwarden.com.[25,26]
- **Cost:** The basic password manager is free; Bitwarden calls it "Always free." Premium is $19.80 a year (shown as $1.65 a month, billed annually), and there's a Families plan.[26] *Labeled: paid upgrades available.*

- **What it does:** It creates and saves strong, unique passwords for every account in an "end-to-end encrypted password vault," and works across unlimited devices. Bitwarden says you can use it "for free with no ads."[25]
- **Privacy notes:** Apple's label lists data linked to you and data not linked to you; no tracking is listed.[25] A password manager is only as safe as its main password. Make that one long, memorable, and used nowhere else, and turn on two-step login.

## Have I Been Pwned (website)

- **Made by:** Troy Hunt, a security researcher, who built it "as a free resource."[27]
- **Where to get it:** haveibeenpwned.com.
- **Cost:** Free for individuals to check.[27]
- **What it does:** It lets you check whether an account of yours may have been exposed in a data breach. All its data comes from breaches where data was exposed to people who shouldn't have seen it.[27]
- **Privacy notes:** You type in your email address to check it. If it shows up, change that account's password and any other account where you used the same one.

## FEMA app (emergencies and weather)

- **Made by:** Federal Emergency Management Agency.[28]

- **Where to get it:** Apple App Store.[28]
- **Cost:** Free.[28]
- **What it does:** Real-time weather and emergency alerts from the National Weather Service and the national public alert system for up to five locations by zip code, plus guidance on making a family emergency plan and building an emergency kit.[28]
- **Privacy notes:** Apple's label lists only "Data Not Linked to You."[28] Adding a parent's zip code lets you see alerts where they live.

## What to do

1. Turn on your phone's built-in unknown-caller and spam settings today.
2. Turn on your carrier's free scam blocking.
3. Use a password manager, and check your email at Have I Been Pwned.

CHAPTER 6

# Accessibility

Some of the most impressive free apps were built with and for people with disabilities. Many of them are useful for anyone with aging eyes or ears.

## Be My Eyes

- **Made by:** Be My Eyes.[29]
- **Where to get it:** Apple App Store and bemyeyes.com.[29,30]
- **Cost:** Free. Its website says “Free and unlimited calls.”[30]
- **What it does:** It connects people who are blind or have low vision with sighted volunteers through live video, and it also offers an AI image describer called “Be My AI.” Volunteers are available “for free – 24 hours a day, 7 days a week.”[29]
- **Privacy notes:** Its website says volunteers “only hear your voice and see what you share through your camera.”[30] Apple’s label lists data linked to you.[29] Don’t point the camera at bank cards, passwords, or mail with your Social Security number when talking to a volunteer.

## Seeing AI

- **Made by:** Microsoft Corporation.[31]
- **Where to get it:** Apple App Store.[31]
- **Cost:** Free. The listing calls it “a free app that narrates the world around you.”[31]
- **What it does:** Designed “with and for the blind and low vision community,” it reads text aloud as soon as it appears in front of the camera, describes photos, and scans product barcodes.[31]
- **Privacy notes:** Apple’s label lists only “Data Not Linked to You.”[31]

## Lookout (Android)

- **Made by:** Google.[32]
- **Where to get it:** Google Play.[32]
- **Cost:** Free.
- **What it does:** Lookout “uses computer vision and generative AI to assist people with low vision or blindness.” It can read text and documents aloud and identify objects, people, and text around you.[32]
- **Privacy notes:** Google Play’s label says it may collect personal info, messages, and other data types, shares no data with third parties, encrypts data in transit, and lets you request deletion.[32]

## Live Transcribe & Sound Notifications (Android)

- **Made by:** Google.[33]
- **Where to get it:** Google Play. On most Android phones, it's in Settings, then Accessibility.[33]
- **Cost:** Free.
- **What it does:** It turns speech into text on your screen in real time, in more than 80 languages and dialects, to make conversations more accessible for people who are deaf or hard of hearing. Sound Notifications can alert you to sounds around you.[33]
- **Privacy notes:** Google Play's label says it may collect personal info, audio, and other data types, shares no data with third parties, and that data can't be deleted.[33]
- **On iPhone:** Look for Apple's own accessibility settings. Remember the lookalike warning in Chapter 1: apps on the App Store with the name "Live Transcribe" may be from other developers.[18]

## What to do

1. If someone you love has low vision, install Be My Eyes and Seeing AI (iPhone) or Lookout (Android) together and practice reading a menu or a medicine label.
2. If someone has trouble hearing, set up Live Transcribe on Android, or your iPhone's built-in accessibility features, before the next family dinner.

CHAPTER 7

# Family and Caregiving

Caring for someone, whether a child, a parent, or a partner, is easier when you can share information without a dozen phone calls.

## Find My and Check In (built into iPhone)

- **Made by:** Apple. Built into iPhone.[34]
- **Cost:** Free.
- **What it does:** You can share your location once, share your ETA, or share your ongoing location with trusted people for an hour, until the end of the day, or indefinitely. **Check In** in Messages automatically lets a family member or friend know when you've arrived, and shares your location only if you're unexpectedly delayed and don't respond.[34]
- **Privacy notes:** Location sharing is personal. Apple says you can stop sharing at any time, and that **Safety Check** can quickly stop sharing information if your personal safety is at risk. It also warns that deleting the Find My app does not stop sharing your location.[34]

## Google's Find Hub (Android)

- **Made by:** Google.[35]
- **Where to get it:** Google Play.[35]
- **Cost:** Free.
- **What it does:** Shows your phone, tablet, headphones, and other devices on a map, plays a sound to find a lost device, lets you lock or erase a lost device, and lets you share your live location with friends and family.[35]
- **Privacy notes:** Google says location data in the Find Hub network is encrypted and "not visible even to Google." Google Play's label says it may collect location, personal info, and other data types.[35]

## Google Family Link (for children's devices)

- **Made by:** Google.[36]
- **Where to get it:** Google Play.[36]
- **Cost:** Free.
- **What it does:** A parental controls app that lets you see how your child spends time on their device, see the device's location, set screen time limits, manage apps, and manage privacy settings.[36]
- **Privacy notes:** Google Play's label says it may collect personal info, financial info, and other data types, and that you can request deletion.[36] Talk with your child about what you can see and why.

## Life360

- **Made by:** Life360.[37]
- **Where to get it:** Apple App Store.[37]
- **Cost:** Free to download, with paid memberships. The App Store lists in-app purchases from $7.99 to $24.99, including Silver, Gold, and Platinum memberships and a 7-day free trial.[37] *Labeled: paid features.*
- **What it does:** Family location sharing, place alerts, and, with paid memberships, features like crash detection and roadside assistance. It also works with Tile trackers for keys, wallets, and pets.[37]
- **Privacy notes:** Read these carefully. Apple's privacy label for Life360 lists **"Data Used to Track You,"** as well as data linked and not linked to you.[37] The listing says the app may use your location even when it isn't open.[37] In 2021, the news site The Markup reported that Life360 had been selling precise location data to data brokers. In January 2022, The Markup reported that Life360 said it would stop selling precise location data, except to Allstate's Arity, and would sell aggregated data to another firm. The Markup also reported that users can opt out of location data sales in the app's privacy and security settings.[38] Check the current privacy policy and settings yourself before you use it.

## CaringBridge

- **Made by:** CaringBridge, a nonprofit.[39]
- **Where to get it:** caringbridge.org and the Apple App Store.[39,40]
- **Cost:** Free. It describes itself as "a no-cost, 501(c)(3) nonprofit health platform" that is donor-supported.[39]
- **What it does:** Lets you post health updates to everyone at once on a private page, keep a journal of a health journey, and coordinate help from friends and family.[39]
- **Privacy notes:** CaringBridge says you control whether your updates are private or public, and that "your personal data is never sold." The app listing describes it as ad-free.[39,40] Choose "private" if your updates include medical details.

## Eldercare Locator (phone and website)

Not an app, but too helpful to leave out. The Eldercare Locator is a public service of the federal Administration for Community Living that connects older adults and families to local services. Call or text **1-800-677-1116**, or visit eldercare.acl.gov.[43]

## What to do

1. Agree as a family on who shares location with whom, and for how long.

2. For a medical crisis, start a private CaringBridge page so you're not repeating hard news call after call.
3. Call the Eldercare Locator to find local help like meals, rides, and in-home support.

CHAPTER 8

# Setting Up a Phone for Someone You Love

Helping a parent, grandparent, or friend set up a phone is one of the kindest things you can do. Go slowly, and let them hold the phone.

## Step by step

1. **Update the phone.** Install the latest system update before anything else.
2. **Add trusted contacts.** Put family, doctors, the pharmacy, the bank's real number (from the back of the card), and neighbors into Contacts. This lets unknown-caller screening work without blocking people who matter.[20]
3. **Turn on scam protection.** On iPhone, set Screen Unknown Callers to "Ask Reason for Calling" or "Silence."[20] On Android, make sure caller ID and spam protection is on.[21] Turn on the carrier's free blocking (Chapter 5).
4. **Set up emergency information.** Fill in Medical ID or the Android equivalent with the person's permission.[8]

5. **Install only what they'll use.** Three helpful apps beat twenty confusing ones.
6. **Set up a password manager or a written password book** kept in a safe place at home.
7. **Practice once.** Make a test call with screening on. Use Check In together on a short trip.[34]
8. **Talk about the "never" rules.** Never install an app because a caller said to. Never read a code out loud to a caller. Never pay with gift cards.

**Example (made up):** Walter, 81, kept getting scam calls. His granddaughter added 40 real contacts, turned on "Ask Reason for Calling," and wrote his bank's number on an index card by the phone. Unknown callers now have to say who they are before his phone rings.

## Respect their choices

It's their phone. Explain what each setting does and let them decide. If they want location sharing off, that's their right.

CHAPTER 9

# A Twice-a-Year App Checkup

Set a reminder for spring and fall. It takes about 20 minutes.

## Step 1: Delete apps you don't use

Fewer apps means fewer permissions, fewer updates, and fewer places for your data to leak.

## Step 2: Review permissions

Go to your phone's privacy settings and check which apps can see your location, contacts, photos, microphone, and camera. The FTC suggests turning off unnecessary permissions or deleting apps that ask for a lot of permissions they don't need.[19]

## Step 3: Review subscriptions

On an iPhone, open Settings, tap your name, then tap **Subscriptions**.[41] On Android, go to subscriptions in the Google Play app.[42] Cancel anything you don't use. Apple suggests canceling a trial at least 24 hours before it ends if you don't want it to renew.[41] Google notes that uninstalling an app does not cancel its subscription.[42]

## Step 4: Check your passwords

Use your password manager's tools, or check your email at Have I Been Pwned.[27]

## Step 5: Update emergency information

Make sure Medical ID and emergency contacts are still correct.[8]

APPENDIX

# The One-Page Helpful Apps Checklist

*Print this page. Free to copy and share. Prices change; always check the official store listing.*

**REMEMBER: Download only from the App Store or Google Play. Check who made the app and whether it has In-App Purchases.**

**Before you download**

- ☐ The developer's name is the real company or agency
- ☐ I read the price line and any In-App Purchases
- ☐ I read the privacy label (written by the developer)
- ☐ Nobody on a phone call told me to install it

**Set up today**

- ☐ Screen or silence unknown callers (iPhone) / caller ID & spam on (Android)
- ☐ Carrier's free scam blocking turned on
- ☐ Medical ID or emergency info filled in
- ☐ Credit frozen at Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion (free)
- ☐ Password manager or a password book at home
- ☐ Location sharing agreed with family (and Check In tried)

**Helpful picks from this book**

- **Cooking:** Mulberry Tree (free; paid plans) · USDA FoodKeeper (free)
- **Health:** Medicare "What's covered" (free) · Medical ID (built-in) · Medisafe (paid options) · GoodRx (read privacy notes)
- **Money:** Propel for EBT (free, ads) · official IRS app (free)
- **Safety:** Bitwarden (free; paid options) · FEMA app (free) · haveibeenpwned.com
- **Accessibility:** Be My Eyes · Seeing AI · Lookout · Live Transcribe (all free)
- **Family:** Find My / Check In · Find Hub · Family Link · CaringBridge (all free) · Life360 (paid options; read privacy notes)

**Twice a year:** ☐ Delete unused apps · ☐ Review permissions · ☐ Cancel unused subscriptions · ☐ Update emergency info

**Local help for older adults:** Eldercare Locator **1-800-677-1116**

*From* Apps That Actually Help *by D.A. Williams. Sources are in the book's Notes.*

RESOURCES

# Where to Get Help

All of these were checked in October 2026. Look up any organization's official website yourself.

*This book is not legal, medical, or financial advice.*

## Report scams and privacy problems

- **FTC:** ReportFraud.ftc.gov · consumer.ftc.gov for privacy tips.[19]

## Help for older adults and caregivers

- **Eldercare Locator:** 1-800-677-1116 (call or text) · eldercare.acl.gov.[43]
- **CaringBridge:** caringbridge.org.[39]

## Credit freezes

- **FTC guide to credit freezes and fraud alerts:** consumer.ftc.gov.[16]

## Official app makers mentioned in this book

- **Medicare "What's covered":** Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services.[6]
- **USDA FoodKeeper:** foodsafety.gov.[4]
- **IRS app:** Internal Revenue Service.[15]
- **FEMA app:** Federal Emergency Management Agency.[28]
- **VA: Health and Benefits:** U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs.[12]

## Companion guides in this series

*Protect Your Parents*, *After a Scam*, *Is That Really Their Voice?*, *Stop Before You Pay*, *When Banks Cheat You*, *Naked Short Selling*, *Disability Benefits Made Simple*, and *Don't Get Doxxed*, all by D.A. Williams and free to share.

# Notes

Web addresses were checked in October 2026. Prices, features, age ratings, and privacy labels come from official app store listings and company websites as they appeared in October 2026. Privacy labels are provided by app developers and are not independently verified by Apple or Google. This book does not repeat user ratings.

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